

Key HR initiatives

- Action based on daily job satisfaction survey
- Dedicated gender equity initiatives that cover the full spectrum
- Flexible work policies, with leaders having the power to make decisions
- Introduction of two new leadership principles that advocate empathy for fellow employees and accountability to local communities, planet, and future generations
- Launched Project Harmony to help employees share experiences with colleagues and receive tips on handling stress; Alexa and chatbots introduced to on-boarding process to help reduce constraints



time to help it come a step closer to the dream of Bezos.

Meanwhile, Amazon's gender equity initiatives cover the full spectrum with dedicated programmes for the grassroots-, middle management- and senior levels. At the grassroots level, Amazon WoW offers a networking platform for all women engineering students in India. It allows them to connect with Amazon's leaders and recruiters, participate in skill-building sessions, utilise available resources, converse with alumni on their career experiences, and get hired if found suitable. Pinnacle helps middle management women grow into leadership roles. "We realised that this is the time of their career when women go through different life stages including marriage, becoming mothers, having teenager kids or aged parents to look after... We invested in group mentoring so that they can learn from what others are doing to handle the stress," says Varma. At the senior level, Sunshine offers a platform for women leaders across industries to engage with and get mentored by the biggest leaders at Amazon.

Varma says the company is not rushing to get its employees back to office. "There are people operating out of offices, but we have not mandated it. Our workforce is very different, comprising of various departments—including Prime Video, operations team, technology team, Alexa Labs, AWS—so we can't have a one-size-fits-all policy. Our policy is to offer flexibility but give the onus to

the leader of the team to decide how many days they need to work from office or home," she says. Amazon was experimenting with flexi models even before the pandemic, she adds. During Covid-19, it hastened the process of implementing some of these, which helped to fast-track the transition to remote working at the peak of the pandemic.

Varma says Amazon would have a hybrid model. "Amazon had 20,000+ employees joining globally in the last two years. Some of them haven't met their leaders or team in person. So I think there is this excitement to come to office to meet their colleagues and that flexibility is given to the leader [to decide the schedule]."

To deal with the increased stress levels during Covid-19, Amazon introduced Project Harmony—buddies for every team to enable employees to interact with others to understand what they were going through, share experiences, give and receive tips on better work-life harmony and learn how to handle stress. This, Varma says, had a huge impact. It also launched a wellness app for employees, which provided access to health resources offering information on screen time, sleep cycles, nutrition, and mental and physical well-being. Amazon also launched two new leadership principles then. The first was to "Strive to be the Earth's Best Employer" which encouraged leaders to lead with empathy, have fun at work, and make it easy for others to have fun. The second was "Success and Scale Bring Broad Responsibility"; it reminds leaders to be humble and thoughtful about even the secondary effects of their actions and be accountable to local communities, the planet, and future generations.

Then there are initiatives like a launch pad for women who have taken a break in their careers and a platform for employees to recognise the work of their colleagues.

Amazon is using science to make the lives of its employees easier, tough times or not. **BT**

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